Monster Battler Build Spec (inspired by Fight My Monster)

Oct 21, 2026 · @Blaise

Overview

This spec describes a browser game that recreates how Fight My Monster played: grow monsters as collectible cards, then risk them in short PvP fights where strategy rounds tilt a final spinner. Hand the whole doc to Claude Code and build it milestone by milestone (see Build milestones).

What the original was. Fight My Monster was a free-to-play, Flash-based online strategy card game that launched in January 2011, stopped getting content updates after v3.57 in February 2013, and shut down in 2016 (fandom wiki). It targeted boys aged roughly 7 to 11 and pitched itself as a boys' answer to Moshi Monsters (TechCrunch, 2011). By 2012 it reported more than 2 million players and 45 million battles (TMTPost listing).

How to read this spec. Sections marked *Original* describe documented behaviour of the real game. Sections marked *Design choice* fill gaps the public record doesn't cover, so the build is complete and playable. Tune those numbers freely.

Naming and IP. Game mechanics can be recreated, but the Fight My Monster name, logo, monster art and text belong to their owners, and a fan revival already uses the name at fightmy.monster. Ship under an original name with original art. This spec uses the working title **Monster Brawl Club** and placeholder names throughout.

Core gameplay loop

Players grow monsters, risk them in fights, and spend what they win on making monsters stronger, which makes the next fight worth taking.



core loop · 4 steps

A session is short: a couple of fights, a dojo session started, a potion bought. The risk of losing a favourite monster is what keeps fights exciting.

Monsters

Every monster is a trading card with one headline number, **Strength**, plus four strategy skills. Strength is what fights win, lose and steal.

Growing a monster *(Original)*. Players grew monsters rather than catching them. There were three grow tiers, Standard, Super and Xtreme, each producing a different power range. A Monster Builder let players customise and name a monster before growing it (fandom wiki).

Grow tiers *(Design choice for numbers)*:

Tier	Cost	Strength roll	Skill points to spread	Grow time
Standard	free, 1 per day	40 to 80	8	instant
Super	150 nuggets	80 to 150	12	10 min
Xtreme	500 nuggets	150 to 260	16	1 hour

Card fields *(Design choice)*:

- `name`: player chosen, filtered through a word list
- `species`: one of about 12 original body types (furball, mutant, mechanoid, slime, beast, bug and so on), purely cosmetic
- `parts`: head, body, arms, legs, colour palette, picked in the builder

- `strength`: integer, the stake and the fight weight
- `skills`: Attack, Defense, Tricks, Brains, each 1 to 10, sum equal to the tier's skill points plus 4
- `level`: 1 to 20, rises with XP from fights and dojo training
- `rarity`: Common, Rare, Epic, Legendary, rolled at grow time (70 / 22 / 7 / 1 percent), adds +0 / +10 / +25 / +50 percent to the strength roll
- `sheen`: optional shiny variant, 1 in 200 grows, cosmetic only
- `status`: alive, in graveyard, or incinerated
- `owner_id`, `created_at`, `fight_record` (wins, losses)

Levels *(Design choice)*. Each level adds 4 percent to strength and one skill point. XP comes from fights (win 30, loss 10) and dojo sessions. Higher levels unlock card frames, not power spikes, so old monsters stay viable.

Collection limits *(Design choice)*. Free players hold 12 monsters, members 40. This keeps Collect fights meaningful.

Fight system

A fight is decided by one spin of a two-coloured wheel; strength sets the starting split and skill rounds shift it. This is the most important thing to get right.

What the original did *(Original)*. Each monster had four strategy types, Attack, Defense, Tricks and Brains, in a rock-paper-scissors cycle where each beats the next. Strategy rounds influenced the outcome, but a final wheel of chance decided it (fandom wiki). Skill rounds were optional and adjusted the final odds, and the spinner made the call (fightmy.monster FAQ). Reviewers noted that low-odds monsters sometimes won, which kept underdogs hopeful (Common Sense Media).

Fight sequence *(Design choice for detail)*:

1. Challenger picks one of their monsters, an opponent's monster, a stake (Bite, Collect or Eat) and 0 to 3 skill rounds.
2. Defender accepts or declines within 60 seconds. Each side picks its own stake independently.
3. Server computes the starting split from strength and shows both players the wheel.
4. For each skill round, both players secretly pick Attack, Defense, Tricks or Brains within 10 seconds. No pick means a random one.
5. Server reveals both picks, resolves the round and slides the wheel split.
6. After the last round, the wheel spins. The pointer's landing colour is the winner.

7. Stakes resolve, XP and nuggets are paid, and both players see the result screen with the loser's cartoon defeat animation.

The strategy cycle *(Design choice for the pairing)*. Use the order Attack → Defense → Tricks → Brains → Attack, where each beats the one after it:

- Attack beats Defense
- Defense beats Tricks
- Tricks beats Brains
- Brains beats Attack
- Opposite pairs (Attack vs Tricks, Defense vs Brains) and mirror picks are neutral: the higher skill value of the chosen strategy wins the round; equal values tie

Starting split. Monster A's slice of the wheel is its share of total strength, clamped so nothing is ever certain:

```
p_0 = \mathrm{clamp}\left(\frac{S_A}{S_A + S_B},\ 0.10,\ 0.90\right)
```

Round shift. The round winner gains wheel share. The gain grows with the skill gap in the strategy they chose:

```
\Delta = \min\left(0.05 + 0.01 \cdot \max(0,\ k_{win} - k_{lose}),\
0.12\right)
```

Here k is each player's skill value for the strategy they picked that round. A tie moves nothing. Total movement from all rounds is capped at 0.30 either way, and the final split is clamped to 0.05 to 0.95.

The spin. Draw r uniformly from [0, 1). A wins if r < p_final. Use a server-side cryptographic RNG, and publish a hash of the seed before round 1 and the seed after the spin, so players can verify fairness.

Worked example. A has strength 120 and B has 180, so A starts at 0.40.

Round	A plays (skill)	B plays (skill)	Result	A's share
Start				0.40
1	Brains (7)	Attack (4)	Brains beats Attack, A +0.08	0.48
2	Defense (5)	Defense (5)	Mirror, equal skill, tie	0.48
3	Brains (7)	Tricks (6)	Tricks beats Brains, B +0.05	0.43

The wheel then spins with A holding 43 percent.

AI opponents *(Design choice)*. Bots pick strategies weighted toward their two highest skills, with 25 percent random picks so they are not exploitable.

Fight stakes and the graveyard

The stake is what makes fights tense: every PvP fight can cost you strength, the monster itself, or its life.

(Original) Bite lets the loser keep the monster while the winner takes some of its strength; Collect hands the loser's monster to the winner; Eat lets the winner absorb the loser's strength and sends the loser to a graveyard (fandom wiki). Players pick Collect or Eat independently before the fight, so matchups can be mixed, and Bite is the lowest-risk option. Graveyard monsters can be resurrected or permanently incinerated for nuggets (fightmy.monster FAQ).

Stake rules *(Design choice for numbers)*:

Stake	Who must agree	If you win with it	Loser's monster
Bite	both players	your monster gains 10% of the loser's strength	loses that 10%, stays with owner
Collect	chosen alone	the loser's monster joins your collection at full strength	changes owner
Eat	chosen alone	your monster gains 40% of the loser's strength	goes to the owner's graveyard

- Each player's own stake decides what happens if *they* win. A Collect player facing an Eat player risks being eaten but only collects if they win.
- Collect into a full collection: the monster is auto-sold for nuggets equal to its strength.
- Eat into a full graveyard: downgrade to Bite so a child never loses a monster with no way back.
- Practice fights against bots have no stake and pay half XP.

Graveyard *(Design choice)*. Holds 5 monsters (members 15). Resurrect costs 2 nuggets per strength point and returns the monster at 50 percent strength. Incinerate removes it forever and refunds 10 nuggets.

Economy and progression

One soft currency, **nuggets**, ties everything together: earned from fights and minigames, spent on growing, potions, training and resurrection.

(Original) The Monster Village held a market, a monster trader, the monster builder, a potion shop and a dojo, and potions changed strength and fight stats (fandom wiki). Kids could earn points in educational and arcade minigames (Common Sense Media). A paid subscription launched in 2011 (TechCrunch).

Village buildings *(Design choice for detail)*:

Building	What it does	Key numbers
Monster Builder	pick parts, colours and name, then grow at a tier	see Grow tiers
Market	buy bot-listed monsters; list your own for sale	5% listing fee
Trader	two-player swap screen, both must confirm twice	friends only, 1 trade per pair per hour
Potion Shop	one-fight or permanent boosts	Strength +10% for 1 fight: 40; Skill +1 permanent: 120; Lucky Charm, +0.03 wheel share for 1 fight: 80
Dojo	train a monster while you're away	1 skill point or 3% strength per session; 30 min; 25 nuggets
Arcade	short minigames (maths sprint, memory match, reaction tap)	up to 20 nuggets a game, 200 a day
Graveyard	resurrect or incinerate	see Fight stakes

Earning nuggets *(Design choice)*: daily login 20; fight win 15 plus 5 per skill round won; fight loss 5; level up 50; missions 25 to 100; selling monsters.

Energy *(Design choice)*. 10 energy, one point per PvP fight, refills one point every 20 minutes. Practice fights are free. This paces play for young players.

Map ladder *(Design choice)*. A vertical map of 10 regions. Each region has a strength band and a boss bot. Beat the boss to move up; PvP matchmaking prefers players in your region or one either side.

Profile level *(Design choice)*. Account XP is the sum of all monster XP; profile levels unlock buildings (Trader at 3, Dojo at 5) and cosmetic badges.

Membership *(Design choice)*. Optional subscription: bigger collection and graveyard, 2 dojo slots, member-only parts. Never sells fight power directly.

Social, safety and parent features

The audience is children, so safety is a launch requirement, not a later feature.

(Original) About 20,000 parents registered, and a parent centre let them watch their child's interactions and unfriend or block other users (TechCrunch). Kid reviewers liked the blocking tools but complained about rude players (Common Sense Media kid reviews). Defeats were cartoonish, such as a weight squashing the loser, never gory (Common Sense Media).

Build these *(Design choice)*:

- Friends list, challenge a friend, fight history, public monster cards
- Chat from a fixed phrase menu only ("Good fight!", "Rematch?"), no free text at launch
- Usernames picked from generated word pairs, never typed freely
- Block and report on every profile and fight result screen
- Parent account linked by email: sees fights, trades and friends; can block, cap daily play time, and turn off Collect and Eat stakes
- Trades and Collect/Eat stakes off by default for new accounts until a parent approves
- No real-money purchases without a parent PIN
- Store the minimum personal data; check the UK Age Appropriate Design Code and COPPA before launch

Technical architecture and data model

Build a server-authoritative TypeScript web app: the client only displays fights, the server rolls every number. *(All Design choice; the original ran on Flash.)*

Stack:

- Monorepo with pnpm workspaces: `apps/web`, `apps/server`, `packages/shared` (types, fight maths, constants)
- Web: React + Vite + TypeScript, Tailwind for UI, PixiJS for the wheel, card art layering and defeat animations
- Server: Node + Fastify (REST) + Socket.IO (live fights and challenges)
- Data: PostgreSQL via Prisma; Redis for online presence, matchmaking queues and in-flight fight state

- Auth: email + password for parents, child logins created under a parent; sessions in HTTP-only cookies
- Tests: Vitest for `packages/shared` fight maths (100% coverage), Playwright for one full fight between two browsers

Monster art *(Design choice)*. Layered SVG parts (head, body, arms, legs, eyes, mouth) recoloured with a palette, so the builder can generate thousands of combinations from about 60 drawn parts.

Core tables:

Table	Key columns
`users`	id, username, role (child/parent), parent_id, nuggets, energy, energy_updated_at, profile_xp, is_member
`monsters`	id, owner_id, name, species, parts_json, palette, strength, atk, def, tricks, brains, level, xp, rarity, sheen, status, wins, losses, created_at
`fights`	id, challenger_id, defender_id, monster_a_id, monster_b_id, stake_a, stake_b, rounds_planned, p_start, p_final, seed_hash, seed, roll, winner_monster_id, state, created_at
`fight_rounds`	fight_id, round_no, pick_a, pick_b, winner, delta
`potions_active`	monster_id, potion_type, fights_left
`trades`, `market_listings`	standard offer/accept rows with a state column
`friendships`, `blocks`, `reports`	user pairs plus status
`ledger`	every nugget change: user_id, amount, reason, ref_id

Fight state machine: `PENDING → ACCEPTED → ROUND_PICKING ⇄ ROUND_REVEAL → SPINNING → RESOLVED`, with `DECLINED`, `EXPIRED` and `ABANDONED` exits. An abandoned fight after acceptance counts as a loss for the leaver.

Socket events: `challenge:send`, `challenge:respond`, `fight:start`, `round:pick`, `round:reveal`, `fight:spin`, `fight:result`. The client never sends numbers, only picks and accept/decline.

Integrity rules:

- Resolve each fight in one database transaction: ownership transfer, strength changes, graveyard moves and ledger rows commit together
- Lock both monsters when a challenge is accepted so they can't be traded or entered in a second fight
- Rate-limit challenges (10 a minute) and trades
- Put all tunable numbers in one `balance.ts` file in `packages/shared`

Build milestones for Claude Code

Build in six milestones, each playable on its own; don't start the next until the current one's checks pass.

1. **Fight maths, no UI.** `packages/shared`: strategy cycle, starting split, round shift, caps, spin, stake resolution. Unit tests for every rule, including the worked example (A ends at 0.43).
2. **Single-player fight.** Hard-coded monsters, a fight screen with four strategy buttons, a 10-second timer, the wheel and a spin animation, against a bot.
3. **Monsters and accounts.** Postgres, sign-up, Monster Builder with layered SVG parts, three grow tiers, collection screen with cards.
4. **Live PvP.** Socket.IO challenges, simultaneous secret picks, server-side seeded RNG with seed hash, stakes, graveyard, fight history. Playwright test with two browsers.
5. **Village and economy.** Nuggets ledger, potion shop, dojo timers, market, trader, arcade with one minigame, energy, map ladder with boss bots.
6. **Safety and polish.** Parent accounts and controls, phrase chat, block and report, sound, defeat animations, mobile layout.

Paste this into Claude Code to start:

```
I want to build a web game called Monster Brawl Club. The full spec is below.
It is inspired by the mechanics of the old Flash game Fight My Monster, but
must use only original names and art.

Work in milestones. Start with Milestone 1 only: create a pnpm monorepo with
apps/web, apps/server and packages/shared, then implement the fight maths in
packages/shared exactly as the spec describes (strategy cycle, starting
split,
round shift with caps, spin, stake resolution), with Vitest tests for every
rule and the worked example. Put every tunable number in balance.ts.

When Milestone 1 tests pass, stop, summarise what you built, and wait for me
before starting Milestone 2.

[paste the whole spec here]
```

Export the doc as Markdown and paste it where the prompt says, so Claude Code sees every rule and number.

Sources

- Fight My Monster Wiki (fandom): strategy types, stakes, grow tiers, village, dates
- fightmy.monster FAQ: skill rounds, spinner, independent stakes, graveyard (fan revival project)
- TechCrunch, June 2011: audience, parent centre, subscription
- Common Sense Media review: defeat animations, underdog wins, minigames
- Common Sense Media kid reviews: what players liked and disliked
- TMTPost listing: 2012 player and battle counts

All numbers not marked *Original* are design choices for this build.